

Chapter 119-1

Yan Xi's older sister came to visit the set, and filming for the crew was temporarily halted.

The director was inwardly displeased but could only silently endure it without losing his temper. After all, everyone knew she was a young miss with background and backing.

Even though the director had great fame and talent, if he could avoid offending capital, he chose not to offend it.

At worst, they would wait half an hour—the entire crew could afford that much.

However, the director hadn't rested for long before he called for the second unit to come film Liang Shi's solo scenes.

He came personally to discuss it with Liang Shi because the solo scene she was filming was emotionally heavy—it was a big crying scene.

He didn't know if she could get into the right emotional state quickly.

Based on her performance during the previous audition, the director believed in Liang Shi.

But Liang Shi's performance just now had been barely satisfactory—one could only say she was slightly better than Yan Xi, not in the zone at all.

If this big crying scene was also messed up, the director might really go berserk today.

Yet Liang Shi agreed without hesitation. Looking over at Yan Xi's side, they seemed to still have things to discuss.

Yan Lin was saying something to her, and Yan Xi had her brows tightly furrowed, looking unhappy.

Meanwhile, Shen Hui stood calmly beside Yan Lin, hands stuffed in her coat pockets, aloof and cold.

Liang Shi had already taken out her phone but put it back. Xu Qingzhu had told her before to stop meddling in matters between Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui.

Liang Shi decided to comply. After all, last time had turned into a huge misunderstanding.

She still remembered the scene of being collectively teased by three people—a famous scene of social death.¹

Solo shots were easier to film than two-person shots. She sat there and went through the lines again.

There weren't actually many lines; what mattered most were the expressions and emotions. The essence of a crying scene wasn't in shedding tears, but in being sad without realizing it.

Tears would all accumulate in the eye sockets, constantly swirling but never falling.

Then at the emotional climax, they would fall like pearls.

This was what beautiful crying looked like.

Most actors' crying scenes weren't very pretty. For a director to achieve a beautiful scene was too difficult—it required great patience to train the actors.

Before filming began, the director went through the lines with Liang Shi once more and confirmed that the emotions and ideas they both wanted to convey were the same before sitting back down in front of the monitor.

The director didn't hold much hope for her either.

As long as she didn't mess it up, that would be enough.

But the moment "Action" was called, Liang Shi's face appeared on the monitor.

That exquisite face was suddenly magnified, yet it could withstand close-up shots without needing any retouching at all.

The most authentic things were the most captivating.

Liang Shi's first take was much better than before, exceeding the director's expectations. However, it was clearly visible that she still hadn't fully recovered her condition.

After the director called cut, he told her to calm herself down a bit and then do another take.

Liang Shi agreed.

She was working hard to enter the character's emotions. In this moment, she wasn't Liang Shi—she was only the character.

This character was experiencing a great storm in life, even more heartbreaking than when she herself had been cyberbullied into leaving the industry in real life.

Liang Shi closed her eyes briefly, asked a staff member for a bottle of water, gulped down a few mouthfuls before slowly exhaling, then wiped the water from her lips with a tissue.

To match the character's image, she was wearing true red lipstick, making her makeup much more glamorous.

Liang Shi murmured through her lines a few more times by herself, each time louder than the last.

She was absorbed in entering the character's emotions, while on the other side, Shen Hui was silently watching her.

When people are doing something they love or excel at, they shine.

Just like Liang Shi right now.

1. Social death (社死): A popular internet slang term referring to an extremely embarrassing moment in a social situation that makes one feel like dying from embarrassment. ↵

Chapter 119-2

Shen Hui didn't know much about Liang Shi—just a few chance encounters.

Plus that one breakfast last time.

She couldn't say she liked this person, but she didn't dislike her either.

The slight hostility she'd had before had dissipated into thin air once she learned that Liang Shi was a married Alpha.

But she still had reservations about Liang Shi's previous attempt to matchmake her with Zhao Xuning.

Shen Hui had the day off today. Her family had been constantly introducing blind date prospects to her, afraid she was stuck on Zhao Xuning and couldn't move on.

After her Nth refusal, today was the first time she agreed.

Because the blind date prospect was her high school classmate, Yan Lin.

Overall, Yan Lin was someone you couldn't find fault with—her height, appearance, family background, and character were all excellent.

But the key point was that the two of them were actually quite familiar with each other.

Although their contact hadn't been as close as before because Yan Lin's girlfriend during university was too domineering, and Shen Hui had been hanging around with Zhao Xuning during university.

But they still kept up with each other's recent activities.

For example, Yan Lin had dated two girlfriends during university and had almost gotten engaged to the second one. But on the eve of the engagement, her fiancée had gotten pregnant with someone else's child.

This incident had spread quite widely in their classmate circle.

As for coming on this blind date with Yan Lin today, it was because Shen Siyan had said: Just treat it as going on a spring outing with an old classmate.

At the time, Shen Hui wanted to retort that it was deep autumn—what kind of spring outing was this? But the words reached her lips and she couldn't be bothered to say them.

Ever since returning from abroad, she had become more and more taciturn.

It seemed... the only time she talked more was in front of Zhao Xuning.

But that was only to provoke Zhao Xuning.

In the most hidden and dark corner of her heart, it seemed like only if Zhao Xuning suffered together with her would it be acceptable.

Otherwise, her pain would lose its meaning.

Shen Hui felt that her current psychology might be somewhat morbid, but as long as she never mentioned it to anyone, she was still normal.

The late autumn sun hung in the sky, and the temperature didn't seem to rise much.

Inexplicably, Shen Hui found herself drawn into the emotions of Liang Shi's acting, and all her sad emotions were infinitely amplified.

When Liang Shi finished her second take and the director called cut, Shen Hui actually shed a tear.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi, who had entered her acting state, had already cried until her eyes were red.

Those eyes were particularly beautiful—the pupils were light brown, and the whites were tinged with red. It wasn't a terrifying scarlet, but rather like the evening glow when the setting sun spread across the sky at dusk.

Shen Hui was staring at her so intently that Liang Shi quickly noticed.

Liang Shi raised her head and unexpectedly met her gaze.

Those were eyes very similar to her own.

Suddenly, Liang Shi remembered what Zhao Xuning's cousin had said: "Of course she looks familiar—just look in the mirror and you'll see!"

They really were quite similar.

However, her and Shen Hui's appearances were completely different.

Shen Hui had a slender figure, leaning more toward a cold beauty with angular features.

Especially when those eyes swept over someone indifferently, it would make people feel a chill.

Whereas Liang Shi leaned more toward a beauty with a sense of strength, and since she liked to smile, her overall aura was very gentle.

They were two completely different styles.

Liang Shi hadn't yet emerged from the character's emotions. She subconsciously wanted to greet Shen Hui, but could only manage a very stiff smile.

After finishing this segment, the first unit took a break.

The second unit went to film less important scenes.

Liang Shi sat there still unconsciously shedding tears.

At times like this, she realized the benefits of having a team. In the past, Xiao Bai would have already handed her tissues, but now she could only cry alone. While crying, she still had to avoid her clothes, afraid that if she got them wet, she wouldn't be able to wear them anymore.

And her hands were trembling badly from the intense emotional fluctuations.

Before long, a tissue was handed to her.

Liang Shi looked up and saw Shen Hui with lowered eyes, her voice very faint: "Wipe your face."

Liang Shi tried to force the tears back by tilting her head up, but it had little effect.

Her hand was still shaking as she took the tissue from Shen Hui.

After handing her the tissue, Shen Hui withdrew her hand, still maintaining that cold and distant appearance, but she didn't leave.

Chapter 119-3

Once Liang Shi's emotions had mostly calmed down, with staff members coming and going around them, Shen Hui suddenly said: "You acted well."

Liang Shi: "?"

For a moment, she couldn't tell whether Shen Hui was criticizing her or praising her.

It was truly impossible to judge from Shen Hui's absurdly flat tone. In the end, she figured it out—Shen Hui wasn't the type to pick fights for no reason.

Since she said that, it must be a genuine compliment.

Liang Shi nodded and said thank you.

The two stood there with nothing to say, both waiting for someone.

Shen Hui was waiting for Yan Lin; Liang Shi was waiting for Yan Xi.

Neither of them were talkative people, and after what happened last time, Liang Shi still felt a bit embarrassed deep down.

In the end, they actually said in unison: "I'm sorry."

After saying it, the two looked at each other in a daze.

Liang Shi was the first to laugh. She wiped her still uncomfortable nose and said gently: "About what happened at the police station last time—I'm sorry. I didn't mean to meddle in the relationship between you two."

"Mm." Shen Hui responded very logically, then said: "I accept. At the same time, I wasn't targeting you last time."

Liang Shi: "..."

Shen Hui said candidly: "I was only targeting Zhao Xuning."

Liang Shi: "..."

That was unexpectedly honest.

"Alright then." Liang Shi smiled awkwardly. "It was irresponsible of me to say those things without understanding the situation. I also never ran into you after that."

The implication being that she hadn't been able to apologize in time.

"It's fine." Shen Hui paused, looked at her, and suddenly said in a drawn-out tone: "Xu Qingzhu has good upbringing."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Your wife already apologized on your behalf." Shen Hui said: "Although she didn't represent you, she explained things to me."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I didn't expect you to come apologize again yourself." Shen Hui's tone was very sincere: "It seems your wife has educated you well."

Liang Shi: "..."

For some inexplicable reason, her ears were burning again.

Chapter 119-4

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After visiting Yan Xi on set, Yan Lin left, and Shen Hui left with her.

After Yan Lin left, Yan Xi's mood wasn't very good.

Her filming state, which was already not great, became even worse—adding frost to snow.¹ She had consecutive NGs over a dozen times.

The director was on the verge of losing it. Liang Shi hurriedly said: "Director, why don't we film this afternoon instead? Yan Xi didn't rest well last night; she's not in the right state."

The director was furious. Not daring to lose his temper at Yan Xi, he roared: "What if she's still not in the right state this afternoon? Nging over a dozen times on such a simple scene—she might as well not act at all! How is she going to film the later scenes!"

The entire crew's atmosphere was low, but they still took a break.

In this situation, not resting would just be a waste of time anyway, and it was torture on everyone's mental state.

Liang Shi brought the still somewhat dazed Yan Xi to the side, handed her a bottle of water, and said with feigned ease: "Student Yan, aren't you supposed to be very talented? You've memorized all your lines—teach me."

Yan Xi had been hanging her head in a bad mood, but upon hearing this, she looked up with watery eyes.

Liang Shi was stunned. "What? Don't cry."

She wasn't good at coaxing people.

Yan Xi let out a light breath. "It's nothing, it's just... Yang Shuyan is going on a blind date, and it's with my grandmother's cousin's granddaughter."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was completely confused by these extended family relationships.

However...

"What does that have to do with you?" Liang Shi asked. "You're letting this affect your state and refusing to film?"

"Yes! What else?" Yan Xi said. "I've lost the meaning of life. Why did I come here to film? Wasn't it all for Yang Shuyan? And now... she she she she..."

Yan Xi was so angry she was trembling.

A few seconds later, Yan Xi continued: "Last night she was even photographed by paparazzi entering the same hotel as Zhao Ying."

Liang Shi: "..."

"It was at our hotel." Yan Xi clenched her fists. "I've been cheated on."²

Liang Shi helplessly pressed her hand to her forehead, momentarily not knowing how to console her.

So she stayed quiet.

As a result, a few minutes later, Yan Xi asked her: "Why aren't you comforting me?"

Liang Shi was exceptionally blunt: "...I don't know how."

Yan Xi was a crybaby and a delicate little princess.

Liang Shi had no experience dealing with this type of person. She just wanted Yan Xi to adjust her emotions quickly so she could get into the right state to film.

She wanted to finish work as soon as possible, after all... there was someone waiting at home.

When this thought occurred to her, Liang Shi was startled by herself.

Home. Waiting.

These two words could actually be bundled together for her, without any sense of incongruity.

Thinking of Xu Qingzhu this morning, she suddenly felt eager to return home.

Even though she hadn't been away for long.

While Yan Xi was still there grieving, Liang Shi took out her phone to message Xu Qingzhu, asking what she was doing.

Xu Qingzhu replied after a while: [Working.]

Liang Shi's thoughts wavered for half a second between not disturbing her work and chatting with her, then decisively replied: [I ran into Shen Hui today.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Aren't you filming? Why would Shen Hui be there?]

Liang Shi: [...You might not believe this, but she's on a date, with your junior's older sister.]

Xu Qingzhu: [That's great.]

Liang Shi: [???

After Liang Shi sent these three question marks, she immediately recalled the message.

But Xu Qingzhu still saw it and asked what was wrong.

After hesitating, Liang Shi still said: "I inexplicably feel like Zhao Xuning is so pitiful."

"Liang-jiějie."³ Xu Qingzhu also sent a voice message. When she called her by this title, the ending tone rose. Her way of breaking up the words was still strange—she liked to pause in the middle of "jiějie." Her cool voice was mixed with the sound of pages being flipped: "Can you put away your saint complex? How is Zhao Xuning pitiful?"

"For one party, the relationship is already over, but the other party is still drowning in it." Liang Shi still answered gently: "Isn't Zhao Xuning pitiful? Shen Hui has already moved forward, but she's still stuck in place."

"She brought it on herself. Who else can she blame?" Xu Qingzhu sent this message and quickly followed up: "I just hope all the beautiful older sisters can bravely and dashinglly welcome their second spring. As for Dr. Zhao... who told her to be a mute?"

Liang Shi: "..."

That was indeed irrefutable.

Was it really hopeless between Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui?

Not really.

Someone who was deeply in love could always find an excuse to come back.

But Zhao Xuning just wouldn't say anything.

One wouldn't speak, and the other wouldn't ask.

Shen Hui stabbed at her again and again, specifically targeting her weak spots, yet she had no reaction, passively and self-righteously bearing everything.

Liang Shi discussed this issue more deeply with Xu Qingzhu. Somehow, they ended up discussing what would happen if Liang Shi became a second Zhao Xuning in the future.

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1. Adding frost to snow (雪上加霜): A Chinese idiom meaning to make a bad situation even worse; similar to "adding insult to injury." ⇐
 2. Being cheated on (被绿了): Chinese internet slang literally meaning "being made green," referring to being cheated on in a relationship. The phrase comes from the historical practice of making the family members of prostitutes wear green head coverings, which evolved into slang for cuckoldry. ⇐
 3. Jiějie (姐姐): Chinese term meaning "older sister," used both for actual sisters and as a respectful/affectionate term for older women. ⇐

Chapter 119-5

Liang Shi paused for a moment, her mouth faster than her brain: "I'm definitely better than her. I'm good at communicating."

Xu Qingzhu's voice carried a laugh: "Are you sure?"

Liang Shi said with great certainty: "Of course. Have you forgotten what I said to you at the beginning?"

Liang Shi felt that she had been quite good at communicating back then, bravely building a bridge of communication between the two of them.

In the voice message Xu Qingzhu sent back, there were seven seconds of blank silence before she said with a complicated expression: "Back then, I thought you were sick."

Liang Shi: "..."

"The kind that needs to go to a psychiatric hospital."

"..."

However, Xu Qingzhu neither agreed nor disagreed with what she said.

She only said in a drawn-out tone: "I hope that one day, you can really communicate properly with me."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I hope that day never comes." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu replied with a message: [I'll stop chatting now, I have to go to a meeting.]

Liang Shi: [Okay, remember to eat.]

When the conversation ended, Liang Shi scrolled up through their chat history. It was almost all trivial, meaningless topics.

But she felt she was being strange.

She had clearly always disliked reporting to people about where she went and what she did.

One person was a complete world, existing in a lonely universe.

Yet just now, she had told Xu Qingzhu who she ran into and what happened on set.

She suddenly had a strong desire to share.

And Xu Qingzhu wouldn't leave her words without a response.

Liang Shi felt this was a nice feeling, a very novel experience.

But what she didn't know was that the desire to share was actually the beginning of liking someone.

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This delicate little princess Yan Xi didn't receive any comfort, but relying on her powerful healing ability as a top student, she got somewhat better.

Mainly, Liang Shi was afraid that if she didn't recover by the afternoon, it would slow down the crew's progress. So during lunch, she had Xu Qingzhu motivate her a bit.

For example: "Love isn't everything in life." "I always go all out to do everything well."
"Emotions are easy to regulate."

Once the goading method was used, the delicate princess's competitive spirit was ignited, and filming went exceptionally smoothly in the afternoon.

The director's face finally showed a hint of a smile, acknowledging that Yan Xi was indeed someone with natural talent.

It was just that in some places, Yan Xi still had some minor flaws.

But minor flaws don't obscure the jade's brilliance.¹

When they wrapped up, Liang Shi even praised her: "As expected of a top student."

Yan Xi raised her head proudly: "Of course! But..."

She paused, her eyes full of pink bubbles: "Can you turn Senior Xu's voice messages into a voice pack and send it to me? I want to use it as my alarm ringtone."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi was like a robot that had been doused with water, freezing for a long time before asking: "Is that appropriate?"

"It should be... appropriate, right?" Yan Xi said. "That way I can wake up every day pumped up and ready to fight."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi didn't give it to her, but she mentioned this to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu said she would specially record one for her.

When the two had a video call that night, Liang Shi couldn't help but sigh: "Teacher Xu's fans are dancing right in front of me. So impressive."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She was reading a book on the other end of the video. Hearing this, she laughed lightly: "Jealous?"

Liang Shi denied it: "How could I be?"

Xu Qingzhu shrugged. She had just turned a page, and her slender, fair fingers landed lightly on the book page as she said teasingly: "Teacher Liang has quite a few fans too."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her intuition told her she probably shouldn't have brought up this topic, but stopping now would make her seem guilty.

Liang Shi stared at her on the screen: "Where?"

Xu Qingzhu made a tutting sound, her cool voice rising with a hint of an alluring tone: "Shi Ru Po Zhu?"²

Liang Shi: "..."

"Wanting to dance on jiejie's collarbones?" Xu Qingzhu said this expressionlessly, but her tone wasn't friendly at all. It made Liang Shi's ears itch, and she subconsciously pinched her earlobe.

Then Xu Qingzhu pushed further, extending even more: "Wanting to slide down jiejie's nose bridge?"

Liang Shi: "Xu Qingzhu..."

Her gentle voice carried a hint of threat.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, meeting her gaze through the screen: "What?"

Liang Shi said through gritted teeth: "I'm going to bite you."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Then you'd better be gentle."

Liang Shi: "..."

On this matter, Liang Shi still couldn't beat Xu Qingzhu.

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1. Minor flaws don't obscure the jade's brilliance (瑕不掩瑜): A Chinese idiom meaning that small defects cannot conceal the overall excellence of something or someone. ⇐
 2. Shi Ru Po Zhu (势如破竹): This is the name of the CP (couple pairing) that fans created for Liang Shi and Yan Xi. The name is a play on words—it's a Chinese idiom meaning "like splitting bamboo" (describing an unstoppable force), but here it combines characters from both Liang Shi (适) and the "zhu" (竹) from what sounds like it could reference their pairing. Xu Qingzhu is referencing fan comments about Liang Shi, showing she's been keeping tabs on what fans are saying about her wife. ⇐

Chapter 119-6

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Progress on set was going fairly smoothly. Yan Xi's condition was pretty good, though the person who had once confidently declared she would definitely be better than Liang Shi was long gone.

After realizing that acting was a technical skill, Yan Xi studied diligently every day, asking questions and even observing Liang Shi's acting.

One day, after filming a very plain scene, Yan Xi couldn't help but praise: "You're so amazing. I was immediately drawn into it."

Liang Shi was surprised: "Isn't this just everyday expression?"

"No, no, no." Yan Xi said: "I've been studying these past few days. Either it's climactic, explosive emotions and events—like arguments and crying scenes—or it's especially calm everyday moments where the dialogue sounds like it could come from anyone's mouth in real life. These two types are the hardest."

Liang Shi: "..."

So this was what a top student was like?

Liking to observe and summarize everything they do.

But it had to be said, Yan Xi's observations made a lot of sense.

Having climaxes and big dramatic swings stimulates the audience—it's the same principle as going to the cinema to watch an action film.

But calm everyday scenes aren't easy to act well, especially for famous actors, because audiences tend to conflate reality with the work.

And everyday scenes are all about conveying emotions, letting the audience immerse themselves and become part of the story.

It looks simple but is actually very difficult.

"And then?" Liang Shi asked her directly.

Yan Xi restrained her smile and asked seriously: "How can I make sure I am me, and the character is the character?"

Liang Shi explained from her own experience and discovered that Yan Xi was squatting while listening, not delicate at all.

Completely different from the impression she'd had when they first met.

And she was taking notes very seriously in a little notebook.

Encountering such a student, Liang Shi also taught very seriously.

When the director saw this, he had the cameraman film this scene to use as behind-the-scenes footage later.

Today they were filming together with the second unit. The second unit was filming scenes between Zhao Ying and Shu Yi—all relatively minor scenes, handled by the assistant director.

Paparazzi had brought professional equipment to stake out and photograph candid shots of Zhao Ying and Shu Yi.

But when they saw these two were also good-looking, they filmed a segment of them as well.

During this time, Yan Xi wanted to drink water but wasn't strong enough to twist open the bottle cap. Liang Shi happened to be nearby and helped twist it open.

The paparazzi captured all of this.

That night, a hashtag exploded: #["Mo Guang" Is A Publicly-Funded Romance Drama Set Right](#)^{#.1}

The paparazzi dramatically added captions, explaining the videos they'd captured that day. Zhao Ying and Shu Yi were alright—they were just joking around on set, though they did seem to have CP chemistry.²

As for Liang Shi and Yan Xi's pair, the caption directly read: Only real couples could do these things, right?

The drama itself already had decent buzz. With Zhao Ying and Shu Yi's addition, plus a director who had produced famous works before, everyone was quite looking forward to it.

Seeing Zhao Ying and Shu Yi at the front, fans got a bit riled up.

The cause was that last night, someone had photographed Yang Shuyan appearing at the "Mo Guang" set, visiting Zhao Ying. That night, they even entered the same hotel—suspected relationship exposure.

The two's fans were tearing each other apart online until the sky turned dark.

One side said some nobody wasn't worthy of their sister; the other side told some ugly thing to get lost.

On the plaza,³ any hashtag with their two names was too filthy to look at.

Passersby and melon-eating spectators⁴ who clicked in were completely confused, having no idea what had happened.

Occasionally a few rational fans would say: Won't believe it until it's officially announced.

Then a few career-focused fans were frantically promoting on the plaza. In any case, they stirred up several "explosive" hashtags.

Yet neither Zhao Ying nor Yang Shuyan responded.

Even their studios were playing dead.

In today's entertainment industry gossip, there's an unspoken rule: not denying is the same as admitting.

1. Publicly-funded romance (公费恋爱): Internet slang referring to when actors in a drama have such good chemistry that fans feel like they're watching a real romance unfold, as if the production is "publicly funding" their love story for viewers' enjoyment. ⇐
2. CP chemistry (CP感): CP stands for "couple pairing." Having "CP chemistry" means two people look like they could be a romantic couple, whether in fiction or real life. ⇐
3. Plaza (广场): Refers to the main public feed on Weibo (Chinese social media platform), similar to Twitter's timeline, where trending topics and discussions appear. ⇐
4. Melon-eating spectators (吃瓜群众): Chinese internet slang for onlookers who watch drama unfold without getting involved, similar to saying "grabbing popcorn" in English. The phrase originated from the image of people casually eating watermelon while watching events unfold. ⇐

Chapter 119-7

After a night passed, fans from both sides were still @-ing the main parties to come out and respond, but no one cared.

Even the hashtag #Zhao Ying Unfollowing# briefly made it onto the latest trending searches.

By the end of all the commotion, Yang Shuyan and Zhao Ying's fans started brainwashing themselves—they were just filming together, it's not like they slept in the same bed.

What's more, Yang Shuyan and Zhao Ying's ideal partner criteria had nothing to do with each other.

The two of them were sworn enemies!

There was no way they could be together.

So passersby started speaking up: Everyone except the fans knows they're together.

[This is really absurd. The fans have already torn each other apart until there's a sea of blood, while the main parties are still being all lovey-dovey.]

[I guess I just don't understand the domestic entertainment industry anymore.]

Fans from both sides rarely united against outsiders:

[No passersby allowed in this fight, iykyk.]¹

[They're not even idols. Is them dating digging up your ancestors' graves or something?]

[They're old enough to date, and it's not like they're cheating!]

[...]

Another round of bloody carnage.

Before the matter with those two was even settled, Zhao Ying made it to trending again—this time with another female celebrity.

Fans instantly exploded.

Several consecutive hashtags appeared: #Zhao Ying Cheating# #Zhao Ying Publicly-Funded Romance# #Zhao Ying Come Out And Explain#.

As Zhao Ying's trending status rose, that video was frequently reposted and gained attention, which then brought in Liang Shi and Yan Xi.

The atmosphere between those two was quite like an idol drama.

So completely opposite from Zhao Ying's side, their side was all about shipping based on looks.

[Does this CP have a supertopic?² I want to go check it out.]

[GKD³ for this drama—Oxygen Girl X Domineering Villain Boss, redemption-type love.]

[But they're a BE!]⁴

[...Hearing BE instantly killed my interest.]

[What are you scared of? BE in the drama, HE in reality⁵ is what's exciting! I'm diving in first.]

Before long, a CP supertopic for the two was created, named "Oath."

Fans accumulated faster than their Weibo follower growth.

While these hashtags hung on Weibo, stirring up bloody storms across the internet, the "Mo Guang" crew was working overtime filming.

Zhao Ying was so tired she was entirely relying on coffee to maintain her condition.

Yang Shuyan came by the set during the day, made a round, then went back to the hotel.

The entire time she was on set, she didn't speak to Zhao Ying at all—she only talked with the director.

By the time they wrapped, it was already past 11 PM. Everyone was exhausted.

Zhao Ying yawned and threw on a jacket, planning to go back to the hotel and sleep like the dead. But her manager rushed over: "You're trending again."

Zhao Ying: "..."

Zhao Ying was so sleepy her brain wasn't functioning. She waved her hand dismissively: "Let it trend however it wants to trend."

The manager was helpless: "You're really not going to deny the thing with Yang Shuyan?"

"Let her deny it first, then we'll talk." Zhao Ying said.

The manager scolded her: "Love-brained!"⁶

Zhao Ying glanced at her, her voice drowsy: "Don't stick such a big label on me. I just purely crave jiejie's body."

Manager: "..."

The manager was quite annoyed, but still told her about the Liang Shi situation. Zhao Ying asked if there were any negative comments.

The manager shook her head: "No, there aren't."

"Then don't worry about it." Zhao Ying said. "It's good if it helps her gain some followers."

At the same time, Zhao Ying picked up her phone and without really looking, "accidentally" followed the Oath CP supertopic, then exited out.

Watching her operation, the manager couldn't help but sigh inwardly: Such veteran green tea tactics.⁷

But since it was also to help Liang Shi gain followers, the manager said nothing and obediently went to handle the aftermath.

As for Liang Shi, she found out about this from Xu Qingzhu.

After returning to the hotel and washing up, she greeted Xu Qingzhu as usual, then video-called her. But after connecting, she couldn't see her face.

Liang Shi asked what she was doing.

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1. iykyk (dddd): Chinese internet slang "懂的都懂" meaning "those who understand, understand" or "if you know, you know." ↵
 2. Supertopic (超话): A feature on Weibo similar to a dedicated forum or community page for specific topics, celebrities, or in this case, CP pairings, where fans can post and discuss related content. ↵
 3. GKD: Internet slang abbreviation for "搞快点" meaning "hurry up" or "get on with it," expressing eagerness for something to happen. ↵
 4. BE: Abbreviation for "Bad Ending," meaning the couple doesn't end up together in the story. ↵
 5. HE: Abbreviation for "Happy Ending," meaning the couple ends up together. ↵
 6. Love-brained (恋爱脑): Chinese slang for someone who loses all rational thinking when it comes to romantic relationships, letting love override all other considerations. ↵
 7. Green tea (绿茶): Chinese internet slang for someone who appears innocent and pure on the surface but is actually calculating and manipulative. Here it's used somewhat jokingly to describe Zhao Ying's seemingly "accidental" but actually deliberate action of following the CP supertopic to help boost attention. ↵

Chapter 119-8

Xu Qingzhu: "Looking at you."

Liang Shi: "...Then why can't I see you?"

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm looking at you on the trending searches."

Liang Shi: "?"

"So sweet." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi was completely confused: "What are you talking about?"

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice read aloud with dramatic intonation: "'Oath' is so shippable. The two of them look so well-matched together—Gentle Yujie X Oxygen Sweet Girl."¹

Liang Shi: "...What are you talking about?"

"The CP supertopic for you and Yan Xi." Only then did Xu Qingzhu show her face. "Teacher Liang is famous now, a female celebrity. People are even creating shipping pairings for you."

After several sentences in a row, no matter how slow Liang Shi was, she could tell what this was about.

She didn't bother checking the trending searches. Based on her experience, she already knew what had happened. But looking at Xu Qingzhu on the camera, she smiled after a moment: "Teacher Xu, are you jealous?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "How could I be?"

Liang Shi drew out an "oh" sound, instantly gaining the upper hand. "It's just filming, can't be helped."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Liang Shi said: "There'll probably be even more when the drama airs. The character dynamics in this drama really are quite shippable."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Didn't you read the script before?" Liang Shi even praised. "Although Yan Xi has never acted before, she's quite talented. Especially since her personality fits the character so well. She's been working super hard these past few days. I feel like you top students learn everything quickly."

Xu Qingzhu secretly gritted her teeth: "...Is that so?"

Liang Shi nodded very sincerely, holding back her laughter: "Yeah, she learns faster than Teacher Xu."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Specifically?"

Liang Shi said: "She catches on immediately in many areas."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu suddenly called her full name.

Liang Shi immediately sat up straight, her eyes staring directly at her on the screen. Although she was a bit nervous inside, her expression was serious—only the gleam in her eyes revealed that she was holding back laughter. She responded: "Hm?"

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice said stiffly: "Careful or I'll bite you."

Liang Shi: "..."

After a moment, Liang Shi paused slightly. "Then you'd better be gentle."

She imitated her tone from that day perfectly.

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen for a while, then suddenly laughed and teased: "You learn things pretty quickly too."

Liang Shi imitated her eyebrow raise: "Specifically?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"When learning from me." Xu Qingzhu evaluated sincerely. "And when learning to be bad."

Liang Shi: "..."

Their eyes met through the screen. Neither knew who laughed first.

Suddenly, they both burst out laughing.

After laughing enough, Liang Shi finally said: "There's nothing between me and Yan Xi. I've been very well-behaved here, purely filming."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "I know."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu said calmly: "Yan Xi already called me to explain."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"She said your acting is pretty good, but you're a bit too straightforward as a person." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi was dumbfounded. "In what way?"

"All you do is film, film, film. You don't even talk to other people." Xu Qingzhu adopted an instructive tone. "Teacher Liang, that's not good. You need to socialize more."

Liang Shi: "..."

She really hadn't expected that Xu Qingzhu had planted a spy beside her.

1. Yujie (御姐): A Japanese-derived term (onee-san type) used in Chinese to describe a mature, elegant, and often somewhat cool or commanding older woman. "Oxygen Sweet Girl" refers to a fresh-faced, youthful type who gives off a refreshing, pure vibe like a breath of fresh air. ⇐

Chapter 119-9

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It wasn't until right before bed that Liang Shi remembered to check the trending searches. The buzz around her and Yan Xi's CP had already died down.

But late at night, Liang Shi scrolled past a familiar name: Chen Liuying.

The hashtag was #Chen Liuying's Artistic Photos Are So Alpha#.

Liang Shi originally didn't really want to click on it, but her finger slipped and she clicked in. At the very top was Chen Liuying's Weibo post.

She still had a few die-hard fans, but most were cursing at her.

The photos were actually taken quite well—black and white tones, very atmospheric. You could tell at a glance they had the quality of a magazine spread.

Combined with her looks, if she hadn't caused trouble, she really could have done quite well in the entertainment industry.

But she just had to stir up that whole incident, and now all her endorsements and drama contracts were gone.

Liang Shi hadn't seen her or Bai Weiwei since then. She only heard from Xu Qingzhu that Bai Weiwei's family business had run into a crisis, so Bai Weiwei had returned to work at her family's company and left the entertainment industry.

Only Chen Liuying was left alone.

She didn't know what the status of their relationship was, but they had probably broken up.

Liang Shi couldn't help but sigh.

Though it wasn't undeserved.

For celebrities with dirt on them online, buying trending searches every now and then to boost their visibility, brushing up netizens' goodwill, and testing the waters to see if they could make a comeback—these were all very normal operations.

So Liang Shi could tell at a glance that this was Chen Liuying testing the waters.

But fans nowadays were incredibly shrewd—they understood the entertainment industry better than the celebrities themselves.

Chen Liuying's comment section had fallen within half an hour, filled with curses.

Basically everyone was telling her to get out of the entertainment industry.

Liang Shi originally wanted to exit. She couldn't stand seeing this kind of online backlash; it always reminded her of what happened to her back then.

But before she could tap out, she accidentally touched the screen and hit like—though she canceled it at the speed of light.

It still gave her quite a scare.

But this also reminded her that she should do what she used to do—use a side account when surfing online.

Otherwise, it was easy for things to go wrong.

For her, it was just an ordinary finger slip, but Chen Liuying happened to see it.

Chen Liuying stared at the #Oath# hashtag that was sitting right above her own hashtag. Seeing Liang Shi's name made her seethe with anger.

Those insulting comments kept popping up on her phone screen. She watched them in an almost self-torturing manner, her eyes dark with shadow.

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For Liang Shi, this was just a small incident in her daily life.

On the fifth day of filming, after Liang Shi wrapped up and got her phone, she received a message that came out of nowhere: [Tomorrow at ten, Riddle.]

It was from Chen Mian.

Liang Shi thought for a moment before understanding—this was an invitation to meet.

She replied: [You're back in the country?]

Chen Mian was brief and concise: [Mm.]

Liang Shi checked her schedule for tomorrow. Her scenes were all concentrated in the afternoon, so she could go out. She agreed to the meeting.

Early the next morning, Liang Shi got up, put on light makeup, and went to Riddle for the appointment.

She arrived at Riddle Café at 9:40, twenty minutes earlier than the agreed time. She went in, ordered a cup of coffee, and quietly waited for Chen Mian to arrive.

Chen Mian walked into the café right on time.

Because the original owner's memories contained this person, Liang Shi recognized her at a glance.

But the Chen Mian now was drastically different from the one in her memories.

Especially her face.

The Chen Mian in her memories wasn't considered very beautiful, but that teardrop mole was very alluring, and her eyes were the type that once you saw them, you couldn't forget them.

But the current Chen Mian still had the teardrop mole, only without such a strong sense of melancholy—replaced by a few degrees of aggression.

Chen Mian was wearing a black casual loungewear outfit, also with light makeup, French bangs, hair draped over her shoulders, dyed ink blue.

A very artistic hairstyle.

After sitting down, she swept a glance at Liang Shi and said familiarly: "You're not wearing those bizarre outfits of yours. Good."

Liang Shi: "..."

Obviously, she was referring to the original owner's dark history.

Liang Shi smiled awkwardly, didn't respond to that, and just looked at her gently.

Cold sunlight refracted through the huge floor-to-ceiling windows, falling on her somewhat sickly pale face.

She wasn't even this pale in her memories.

It was probably the result of not going outside for a long time.

"What do you want with me?" Chen Mian asked. "Is it for your little sister again?"

Before Liang Shi could deny it, Chen Mian scoffed to herself: "When will you ever come for your older sister?"

Her tone carried mockery.

Liang Shi paused. "I actually did come for an older sister this time."

When these two words came out of her mouth, they carried an inexplicable sense of familiarity.

Liang Shi stared at Chen Mian and said, word by word: "For Sister Qi Jiao."